DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW

SUMMONED TO THE KREMLIN



Advance to The Kremlin.

"Pack a suitcase. It could go either way."

A late-night summons could mean a promotion or an arrest. Officials often kept a bag packed for both.

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW

PLAN OVERFULFILLED!



Advance to Poluchka and collect 200.

"Wages are paid early to celebrate figures that are definitely real."

Plan results were routinely inflated at every level, a practice called pripiski ("write-ins").

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW

MANDATORY EVENING OF CULTURE



Advance to the Bolshoi Theatre. Collect 200 if you pass Poluchka.

"Attendance will be taken. Applause will be timed."

Workplaces handed out theatre tickets, and "cultured leisure" was an official duty.

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW

DOSKA POCHYOTA



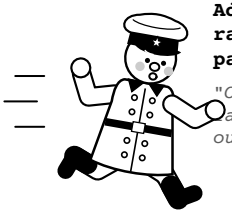
Advance to the Ivanovo Textile Mill and lose 1 Suspicion. Collect 200 if you pass Poluchka.

"The photograph is unflattering, but it's up there, and that's what counts."

Doska pochyota: the Board of Honor, displaying portraits of a workplace's model workers.

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW

KOMANDIROVKA



Advance to the nearest railway. If it's directed, pay its Director double.

"Official travel to inspect a factory that, on arrival, turns out to be a field."

Komandirovka: an official business trip. For many people it was the only way to travel at all.

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW

PROPISKA PROBLEM



Advance to the nearest railway. If it's directed, pay its Director double.

"Your papers say you live here. Your papers are mistaken. There's a train at six."

Propiska: the residence permit stamped in the internal passport. Without one you couldn't legally live in a city.

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW

SUBBOTNIK!



Advance to the nearest utility. If it's directed, roll the dice and pay its Director 10 times the result.

"You have volunteered your Saturday. Your signature is right here, in someone else's handwriting."

Subbotnik: a day of "voluntary" unpaid Saturday labor, a tradition begun in 1919.

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW

YOUR BOND NUMBER CAME UP



Collect 50.

"You've won 50 rubles! You've paid in 2,000. The State congratulates itself."

State bonds paid out by lottery draw rather than interest, so most holders never saw a kopek.

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW

A FRIEND IN THE ORGANS



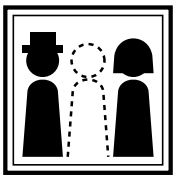
Keep this card until you use it or trade it. Get out of the Gulag free.

"He owes you a favor. Do not ask what he does all day."

"The Organs": everyday shorthand for the organs of state security.

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW

HISTORY HAS BEEN REVISED



Go back 3 spaces.

"You were never here. Please check the photograph."

Fallen officials were airbrushed out of photos and cut from books, sometimes repeatedly as more of them fell.

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW

ARTICLE 58



Go directly to the Gulag. Do not pass Poluchka. Do not collect 200.

"You told a joke. It was a good joke."

Article 58 covered "counter-revolutionary activity," defined loosely enough to include an anekdot, a political joke.

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW **SABOTAGE**

SHTURMOVSHCHINA



Pay 30 per Workshop and 100 per Kombinat.

"Your month-end rush produced 4,000 left boots. Refit everything."

Shturmovshchina: "storming," the frantic last-week scramble to hit the monthly plan, quality be damned.

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW **SABOTAGE**

WRECKERS!



Pay 20 and gain 1 Suspicion.

"A conveyor belt has snapped. It was clearly enemy action, and you were standing nearby."

Vreditelstvo: "wrecking." Ordinary breakdowns and accidents were prosecuted as deliberate sabotage.

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW

YOU'VE WON A PUTYOVKA!



Advance to the Trans-Siberian Railway. Collect 200 if you pass Poluchka.

"A voucher for a Black Sea sanatorium! Curiously, the train is heading east."

Putyovka: a trade-union voucher for a state holiday resort, handed out as a reward.

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW

ELECTED UNANIMOUSLY



Pay each other citizen 50.

"You are now chairman of the housing committee. The vote was held in your absence, which is why you won."

Housing committees settled the endless disputes of communal living, and nobody wanted the job.

DIRECTIVES FROM MOSCOW

STALIN PRIZE, THIRD CLASS



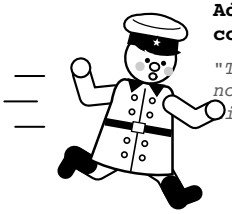
Collect 150.

"It includes a medal, a certificate and an extremely firm handshake."

The Stalin Prize, created in 1940, rewarded science and the arts with cash in three classes.

KITCHEN RUMORS

THEY'RE PAYING TODAY



Advance to Poluchka and collect 200.

"The cashier's window closes at noon, or whenever she feels like it. Run."

Wages were paid in cash at a workplace window, on the kassa's schedule and not yours.

KITCHEN RUMORS

ACCOUNTING ERROR AT GOSPLAN



Collect 200.

"Tell no one. Especially not the person reading over your shoulder."

Planners tracked a continental economy by hand and abacus, so errors were constant and rarely in your favor.

KITCHEN RUMORS

A TOKEN OF GRATITUDE



Pay 50.

"Healthcare is free. The doctor's attention is 50 rubles."

Medicine was free by law. A discreet "thank you" got you seen sooner.

KITCHEN RUMORS

YOU SOLD YOUR PLACE IN THE QUEUE



Collect 50.

"Four hours of standing, sold to a man in a hurry. It's the purest form of Soviet enterprise."

Holding and selling places in line was a genuine cottage industry.

KITCHEN RUMORS

THE PETITION WORKED



Keep this card until you use it or trade it. Get out of the Gulag free.

"Your file landed on the desk of someone who hated your accuser more."

Citizens wrote millions of appeal letters to officials. Once in a while, one worked.

KITCHEN RUMORS

DONOS



Go directly to the Gulag. Do not pass Poluchka. Do not collect 200.

"Your neighbor has written a letter. Your neighbor would also like your room."

Donos: a written denunciation. Coveting someone's living space was a common motive.

KITCHEN RUMORS

PREMIYA



Collect 100.

"The plan was met on paper, so the bonus is paid on paper. Luckily, this paper is money."

Premiya: the bonus for hitting plan targets, often a big slice of real income.

KITCHEN RUMORS

A FIND AT THE TOLKUCHKA



Collect 20.

"The coat cost 10 rubles. The pocket held 20. You're now the most successful investor in the USSR."

Tolkuchka: a "push market," the tolerated flea markets where citizens traded secondhand goods.

KITCHEN RUMORS

COMRADE STALIN'S BIRTHDAY



Every citizen, including you, pays the Secretary 10.

"Your gift is voluntary. The list of who gave is public."

His 50th birthday in 1929 launched the personality cult. By his 70th, the gifts filled an entire museum.

MONOPOLITBURO v0.2.0

KITCHEN RUMORS

GOSSTRAKH PAYS OUT



Collect 100.

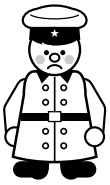
"Your cow was insured. Your cow was also collectivized. Somehow the paperwork favors you."

Gosstrakh: the state insurance monopoly, founded in 1921.

MONOPOLITBURO v0.2.0

KITCHEN RUMORS

VOLUNTARY SOCIETIES



Pay 100.

"You've joined Osoaviakhim, the Friends of the Children and the League of the Militant Godless. Dues are payable now."

Osoaviakhim: a mass civil-defense society. Membership was "voluntary" for its millions of members.

MONOPOLITBURO v0.2.0

KITCHEN RUMORS **SABOTAGE**

BRAK



Pay 50.

"Your enterprise shipped 600 teapots without spouts. The quota only said 'teapots.'"

Brak: defective output, the chronic result of plans that counted quantity only.

MONOPOLITBURO v0.2.0

KITCHEN RUMORS

SHABASHKA



Collect 30.

"You fixed a neighbor's radio with parts that fell off a truck. It was your truck."

Shabashka: an off-the-books side job, often done with materials from one's day job.

MONOPOLITBURO v0.2.0

KITCHEN RUMORS

FOREIGN DELEGATION ARRIVING



Pay 40 per Workshop and 120 per Kombinat.

"Paint everything that faces the road. Only what faces the road."

Foreign visitors toured carefully staged model sites, latter-day "Potemkin villages."

MONOPOLITBURO v0.2.0

KITCHEN RUMORS

SECOND PRIZE, SOCIALIST EMULATION



Collect 10 and lose 1 Suspicion.

"You win a portrait of Comrade Stalin. First prize was two portraits."

Socialist emulation: brigades competed for banners and pennants instead of pay.

MONOPOLITBURO v0.2.0

KITCHEN RUMORS

A PARCEL FROM ABROAD



Collect 100 and gain 1 Suspicion.

"A cousin in America sent gifts and a letter. Several people enjoyed the letter before you did."

Relatives abroad had to be declared on every official questionnaire, and they counted against you.

MONOPOLITBURO v0.2.0